THE FOUR QUESTIONS YOUR ABSTRACT MUST ANSWER

What's your problem?	What gap are you filling? What is contributed?
What did you do?	What's your method/approach? (brief)
What did you find?	What's your argument or result?
What does it mean?	So what? Why should we care?

STRUCTURE & AUDIENCE

- **Length:** 150–300 words
- **Tone:** Third person (usually)
- **Jargon:** Use field keywords, BUT also explain for non-specialists
- **Originality:** Don't cut/paste from paper or poster—re-imagine and paraphrase
- **Stand alone:** Someone should understand it without reading your full work

BALANCING ACT

- Be clear about your contribution—don't undersell it.
- Don't oversell or mislead readers

FOR WORKS IN PROGRESS

Use hedging language:

- might / could / may
- seem / suggest
- preliminary findings reveal
- thus far, we have…

But be clear: What do you *know* vs. what are you *hoping* to discover?

WRITE CLEARLY

- Prefer simple, precise language and avoid circular or "high-falutin'" language. Bigger words aren't necessarily better.
- Eliminate unnecessary words ("to" rather than "in order to").
- Replace vague quantities ("many," "several") with specifics.

QUICK CHECKLIST

- Does it answer all four questions?
- Is every sentence earning its place?
- Can a non-specialist understand it?
- Does it make clear why this work matters?
- Any words that could be cut or simplified?

REMEMBER

A strong abstract is not a description of your project. It is an explanation of what your project contributes to the intellectual conversation.